

Type 2 Diabetes: General Information

What is Type 2 diabetes?

Type 2 diabetes is a long-term condition in which the body does not use insulin well, so sugar (glucose) builds up in the blood. It is the most common form of diabetes in adults. It often develops gradually over years.

Common symptoms

Common symptoms of Type 2 diabetes include increased thirst, frequent urination, increased hunger, unexplained weight loss, tiredness, blurred vision, and slow healing of cuts and sores. Some people have no symptoms for a long time, which is why screening matters.

Risk factors

Risk factors include being overweight, low physical activity, family history of diabetes, older age, a history of high blood pressure, and a history of gestational diabetes. Risk can often be reduced through lifestyle changes.

How diabetes is detected

Healthcare professionals use blood tests. A fasting glucose of 126 mg/dL or higher, or an HbA1c of 6.5 percent or higher, is generally in the diabetes range. A fasting glucose of 100 to 125 mg/dL, or an HbA1c of 5.7 to 6.4 percent, is generally in the prediabetes range. Only a qualified professional can interpret results for an individual.

Managing diabetes

General management includes a balanced eating pattern, regular physical activity, maintaining a healthy weight, regular blood sugar monitoring as advised, and attending routine check-ups for eyes, feet, kidneys and heart health. Medication decisions must be made with a healthcare professional.

Possible complications

Over time, poorly controlled blood sugar can damage blood vessels and nerves. Possible complications include heart disease, stroke, kidney disease, eye damage, and nerve damage in the feet. Good control and regular check-ups lower these risks.